

REFLECTIONS ON PARENTING

- LESSONS FROM TU BISHVAT -

ROSH
CHODESH
Women's Circle

In Honor of Rosh Chodesh Shvat 5766 - 2006

Tu B'Shevat, the 15th of Shevat on the Jewish calendar (this year, Monday, February 13, 2006), is the day that marks the beginning of a "New Year for Trees - Rosh Hashana Lilanot". This is the season in which the earliest-blooming trees in the Land of Israel emerge from their winter sleep and begin a new fruit-bearing cycle.

Legally, the "New Year for Trees" relates to the various tithes that must be separated from produce grown in the Holy Land. These tithes differ from year to year in the seven-year Shemittah cycle; the point at which a budding fruit is considered to belong to the next year of the cycle is the 15th of Shevat.

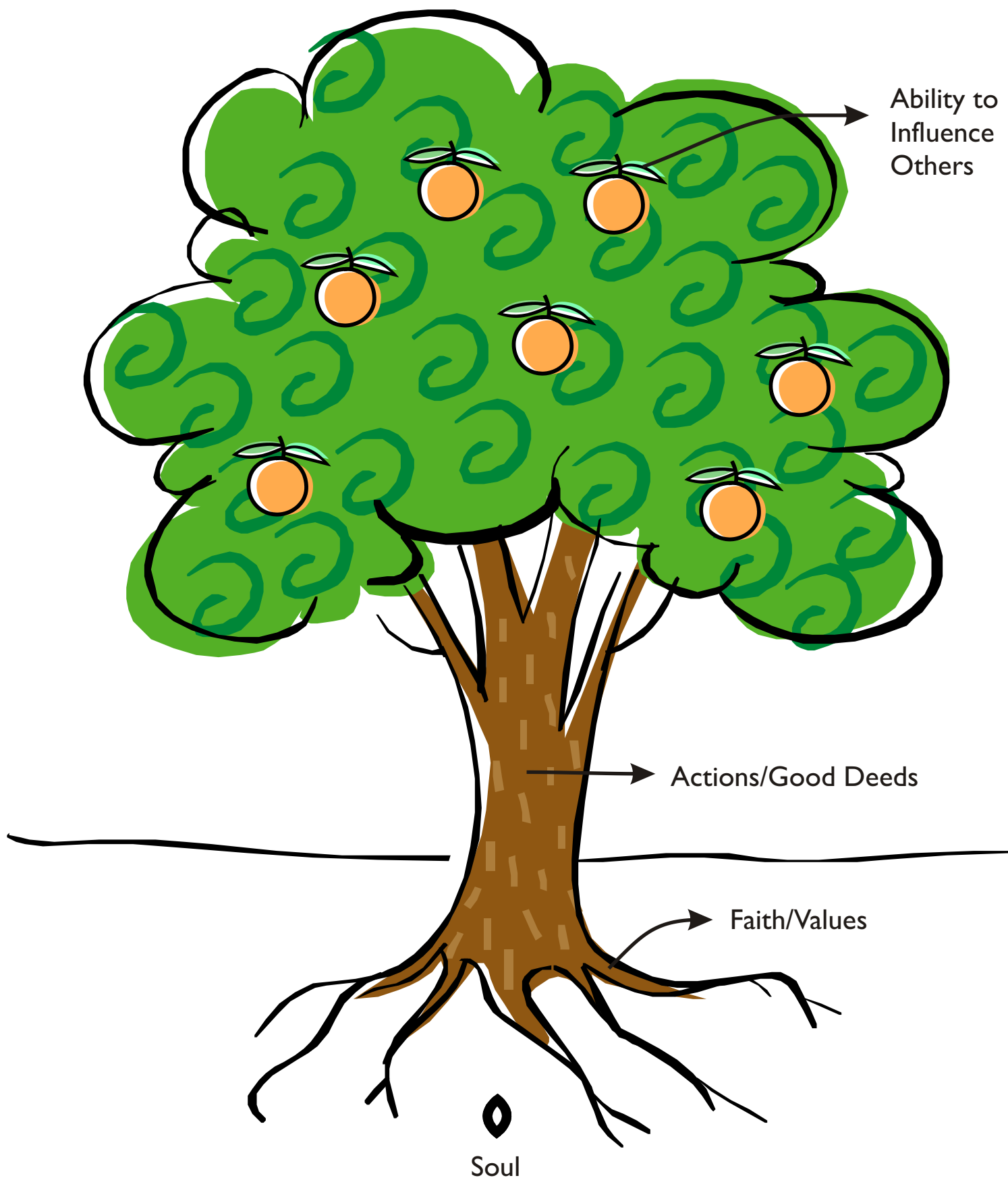
We mark the day of Tu B'Shevat by eating fruit, particularly from the "Seven Kinds" that are singled out by the Torah in its praise of the bounty of the Holy Land: wheat, barley, grapes, figs, pomegranates, olives and dates. On this day we remember that "Man is a tree of the field" (Deuteronomy 20:19) and reflect on the lessons we can derive from our botanical analogue.

Some additional customs for this day:

- The famed Kabbalist, the Arizal, was accustomed to eat 15 varieties of fruits on the 15th of Shevat.
- Many people attempt to eat at least one fruit which one has not eaten that entire season and would require the blessing of Shehecheyanu. When eating such a fruit, the Shehecheyanu should be said prior to reciting the blessing of "Haetz." If he has already partaken of other fruits (at that particular sitting) than he only needs to say the Shehecheyanu upon eating the new fruit.
- The blessing of Shehecheyanu:
 Transliteration: Ba-ruch A-tah A-do-nai E-lo-he-nu Me-lech Ha-olam She-heche-ya-nu Ve-ki-yi-ma-nu Ve-higi-a-nu Liz-man Ha-zeh.
 Translation: Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us, and enabled us to reach this occasion.
- Many also have a custom of eating carob on this day.
- There is yet another custom which many have and that is to eat the Etrog, either in the form of preserves, sugared slices, etc.

“FOR MAN IS A TREE IN THE FIELD...”

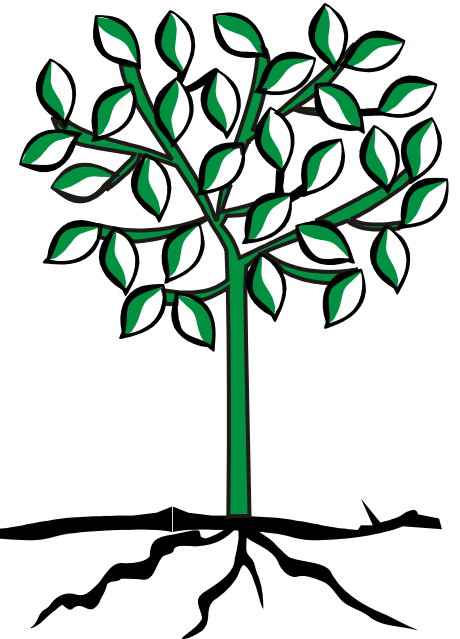
- Deuteronomy 20:19



THE CHILD'S DEVELOPMENT

WHILE GARDENING, THE GARDENER DOES NOT BECOME PERSONALLY BOUND WITH THE PLANTS S/HE IS TENDING.

Although it is difficult not to take our children's behavior personally, as a parent it is vital to remove ourselves and our needs from the picture in order to objectively focus on our child's needs.



PLANTING STAGE

A SEED IS PLANTED PERFECT, WHOLE.

The child's soul is perfect and unblemished. This truth remains unchanged throughout the child's development. Knowing this, we realize that the child's behavior (though not always desirable) is not a reflection on the child's essence & we address the child's actions as opposed to the child. We also work to enable the child to reach his/her ultimate level of self-fulfillment, revealing their soul to the fullest.

EVEN A SMALL SCRATCH ON THE SEED'S SURFACE CAN CAUSE GREAT DAMAGE TO THE FUTURE PLANT'S GROWTH.

The child is extremely vulnerable & sensitive during the early years of development.

NURTURING STAGE

THE SEED FIRST DISINTEGRATES, PREPARING ITSELF TO RECEIVE NOURISHMENT (WATER, SUNLIGHT).

1. As we begin to nurture the child, we observe moments of increased receptiveness in the child and begin instilling life values.
2. "Descent for the sake of Ascent" is a normal part of the growing process.

AS THE SEED DISINTEGRATES & PREPARES FOR GROWTH, NO CHANGE CAN BE SEEN.

There are times when it seems as if the child has reached a plateau, where little or no development is observed. The key is to be patient and consistent, for soon enough our efforts will result in improvement.

SPROUTING STAGE

AS THE PLANT BEGINS TO SPROUT, FIRMLY IMPLANTED TRELLISES HELP DIRECT THE PLANT'S GROWTH.

When not pleased with a child's behavior, a parent focuses on redirecting the child, rather than moralizing. At a moment of mischief or in the heat of a tantrum, simple, uncompromising statements and/or actions are more effective than lessons.

DIFFERENT PLANTS REQUIRE DIFFERENT CARE TO GROW.

"Educate a child according to his way". Different children need different things from their parents. Therefore we cannot be limited to particular parenting styles or tools.

INDEPENDENT STAGE

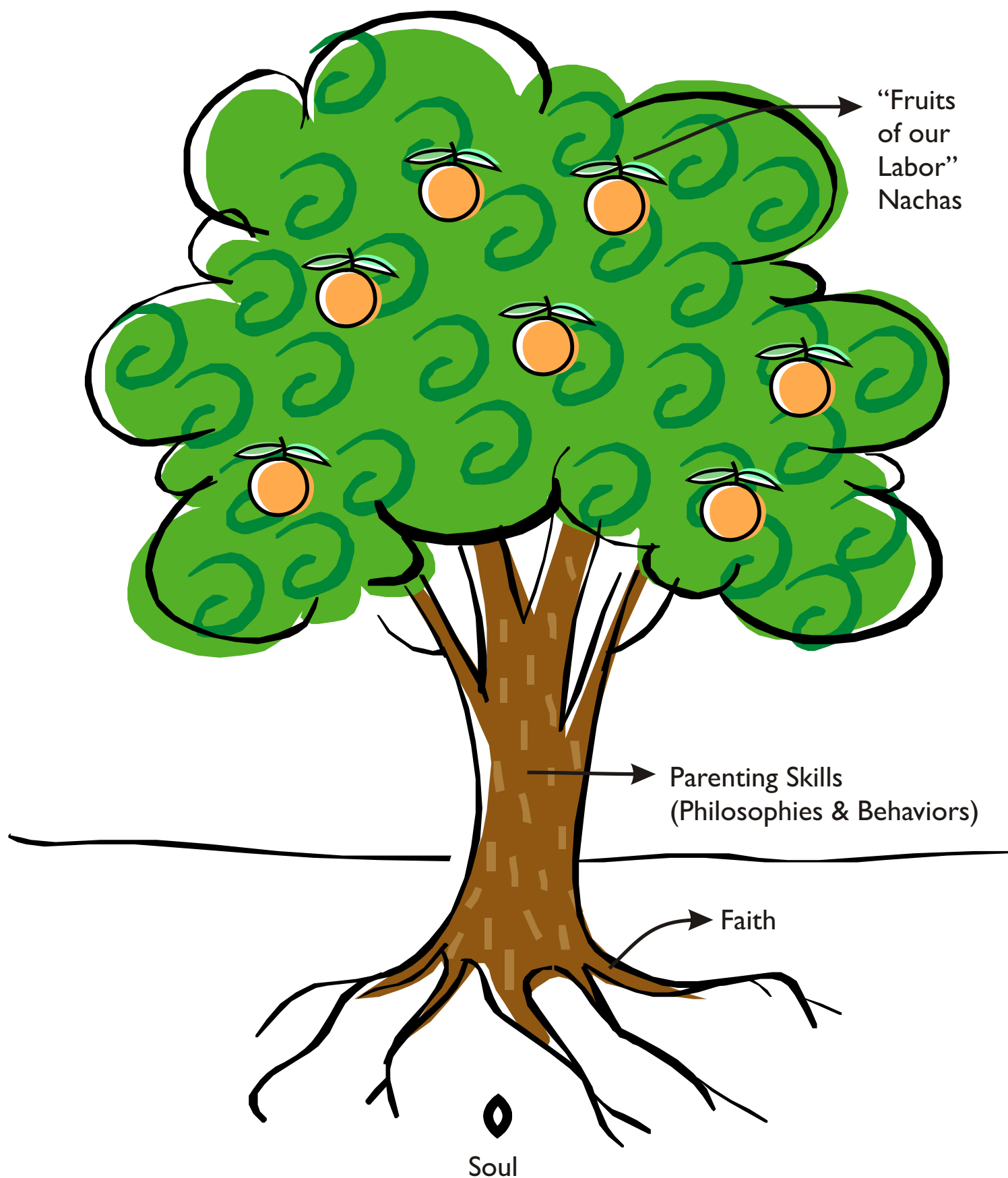
AS THE TREE MATURES, CONTINUOUS CARE MUST BE TAKEN TO PROTECT IT FROM OUTSIDE ELEMENTS.

As the child understands more about the world around them, they are more easily influenced by negative behaviors and attitudes in their environment. As a parent, we set the standards of appropriate behaviors & enforce limits when necessary.

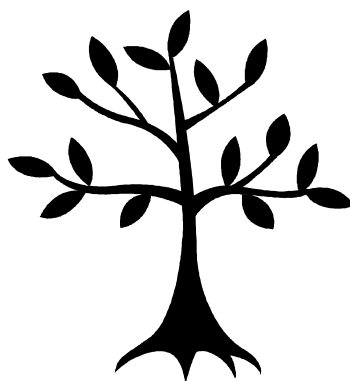
SOMETIMES, A LEAF OR BRANCH ON THE PLANT MAY SHRIVEL UP. AFTER PRUNING & EXTRA NURTURING, THE PLANT SPRINGS BACK TO LIFE.

Sometimes the child goes through a difficult stage & we feel "all is lost". Taking some time to gain perspective on what is really going on, & then acting on our conclusions can help the child back on the right track. The situation is always redeemable.

THE PARENT AS A "TREE IN THE FIELD"



A Parent's True Blessing



There is a dialogue between Rav Nachman and R'Yitzchak. When R' Yitzchak and Rav Nachman were about to take their leave from one another, Rav Nachman asked of R'Yitzchak "May the master bless me". R' Yitzchak said to him: "I will tell you a parable: To what may this be compared? To a man who was traveling in the desert, and he was hungry, tired and thirsty. Then he came upon a tree whose fruits were sweet and its shade pleasant, and a stream of water was flowing beneath it. He ate of its fruits, drank of its water, and sat in its shade. When he sought to leave, he said: Tree, O tree, how shall I bless you? Shall I say to you that your fruits will be sweet? Why, your fruits are already sweet. Shall I say that your shade will be pleasant? Why, your shade is already pleasant. Shall I say that a stream of water will flow beneath you? Why, a stream of water already flows beneath you. Therefore, this is my blessing: May it be the will of God that all the shoots planted from you, will be like you.

R' Yitzchak concludes his remarks to Rav Nachman: "You too, Rav Nachman, with what shall I bless you? Shall I bless you with knowledge of Torah? Why, you already have knowledge of Torah. With wealth? Why, you already have wealth. With children? Why, you already have children. Therefore, this is my blessing: May it be the will of God that your offspring will be like you."

- Talmud, Tractate Taanis, 5B